INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #5 · PARENTS

“I can't be happy until my parents change.”

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Where it often comes from

When parents have hurt us, we may wait for an apology or a change that never comes. Holiday after holiday, we hope this will be the time they finally see us, and each disappointment reopens the wound. Waiting for them to change can quietly put our happiness in their hands.

What Scripture teaches

Paul says, “I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances,” which means that contentment is learned and is not handed to us by other people’s behavior. “Each of us will give an account of himself to God,” and “each one should carry his own load,” so I answer for my choices, and my parents answer for theirs. “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone,” and Proverbs says, “Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life.” We can hope and pray for our parents to change, but our joy does not have to wait for them.

> *“For each one should carry his own load”* (Galatians 6:5).

Also see

> “So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God” (Romans 14:12).

> “I am not saying this out of need, for I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances” (Philippians 4:11).

> “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone” (Romans 12:18).

> “Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life” (Proverbs 4:23).

Common self-statements

- I will never be at peace until they apologize.
- As long as they act this way, I cannot be happy.
- They ruined my life.
- My happiness depends on their changing.
- I cannot move on until they admit what they did.
- I am stuck until they change.

Common logical errors

- Externalizing control: Placing my happiness in someone else’s hands.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I cannot be happy while they stay the same.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either fixed by their change or stuck forever.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling stuck and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- How long have I been waiting for them to change?
- What has the waiting cost me?
- What parts of my life and happiness are in my control?
- What would it mean to hope for change and live well without it?

- What does Scripture say about contentment?
- Who or what can bring me joy now?

Truth summary

> I can hope for my parents to change and still choose to live well. My peace and joy are not owned by their choices. With God's help, I can grieve, set healthy limits, and build a good life now.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Parenting
- Thankful
- Peace
- Hardship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't be happy until my parents change"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't be happy until my parents change." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How long have I waited?
- ☐ What has waiting cost me?
- ☐ What is mine to control?
- ☐ What can bring joy now?
- ☐ What limits do I need?
- ☐ What would contentment look like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My happiness is not in their hands.
- ☐ Each person answers to God for their own choices.
- ☐ I can learn to be content.
- ☐ I can guard my heart.
- ☐ I can live at peace as far as it depends on me.
- ☐ I can build a good life now.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Galatians 6:5
  "For each one should carry his own load."
- ☐ Philippians 4:11
  "I am not saying this out of need, for I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances."
- ☐ Proverbs 4:23
  "Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Joy not waiting: Each day, write one thing that brought you joy that did not depend on your parents.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Philippians 4:11 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I have learned to be content, whatever my parents do.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Count the cost. Write what waiting for their change has cost you.
- [ ] Divide the control. List what is yours and what is theirs.
- [ ] Plan one good thing. Schedule something you enjoy this week.
- [ ] Set a limit if needed. Decide what contact is healthy for you and communicate it calmly.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't be happy until my parents change": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Joy not waiting
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't be happy until my parents change.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have waited a long time for them to change. Help me place my hope in You, release what is not mine to control, and build a good life with the joy You give. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.